by Indrani's husband Ritesh Tahbildar, the police arrested Chaliha on the charges of forcing the woman BJP leader to take her own life. The probe into how the private photographs of Indrani were leaked led the police team to an unexpected discovery: the cash-for-jobs scam.

During a raid at Chaliha's home, the police recovered scores of admit cards of candidates appearing for various government recruitment tests. Besides, audio clips of conversations between Indrani, Chaliha and others exposed cah transactions of cash in exchange for jobs. According to police sources, Indrani and Chaliha had collected a large sum of money from gullible job-seekers with the promise of providing them with government jobs. Some junior BJP leaders helped the duo in this racket. However, when they could not ensure the recruitment of these candidates as promised, the aspirants started demanding a refund of the bribe money. They put pressure on the junior BJP leaders who had collected money on behalf of Indrani and Chaliha.



IN THE NET Accused Diban Deka being taken to a Guwahati court

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INDRANI AND CHALIHA HAD COLLECTED LARGE SUMS OF MONEY FROM GULLIBLE JOB-SEEKERS WITH THE PROMISE OF GOVERNMENT JOBS

In late July, two of these junior leaders from the Nalbari district met Chaliha. An altercation followed in which they not only physically assaulted Chaliha but also took away his mobile phone. Soon, they began blackmailing Chaliha over those alleged intimate photographs and when he did not yield to their demands, the photos were posted on social media with the help of another BJP leader.

During his interrogation, Chaliha reportedly confessed that he and Indrani had taken Rs 3 lakh from each job aspirant, of which Rs 2.5 lakh was paid to senior BJP leaders. They bought cars with the bribe money, Chaliha told the police.

As the probe moved from the suicide towards the cash-for-jobs network, four others—Diban Deka, Rekhanta Das, Ashim Chakraborty and Trishna Sharma—were arrested at different stages of the investigation. Police sources say that Deka, who was the BJP Kisan Morcha's national executive member, allegedly circulated the photographs. He was earlier arrested in October 2020 for his alleged role in the Assam Police recruitment exam paper leak scam, following which he was expelled by the party. Deka, who was released from jail recently, had contested the assembly polls as a BJP candidate in 2011.

Das, who was relieved of all party responsibilities after his name cropped up in the cash-for-jobs scam, was Nalbari district president of the Morcha. Chakraborty is a BJP member from Nalbari district. Sharma, who was BJP Kisan Morcha joint office secretary, has also been expelled from the party. Apart from those arrested, the police have also interrogated several other mid-level BJP leaders, including Sanjiv Sharma, Kapil Talukdar, Mriganka Barman and Pranab Jyoti Lahkar.

During the interrogation, the five arrested have reportedly taken the names of some senior BJP leaders, though police sources did not confirm such reports. One such name doing the rounds is of a veteran BJP organisational leader who has recently been transferred out of Assam to a northern state. There was speculation in the media that former Assam BJP president and minister Siddhartha Bhattacharya was involved in this job-selling racket, following which the veteran leader sent a strongly-worded letter to current president Bhabesh Kalita. "It's sad that many conspiracies against senior BJP workers like me are being undertaken within the